

Security Symantecs

Norman Kohlberger is the Senior Regional Products Manager of Symantec's Consumer Products Division for the Asia Pacific region. He was in Mumbai to launch Symantec's Norton 2004 product range. Digit caught up with him, and spoke to him about security from the end-user's perspective

Digit (D): Here in India, how different is the market from the rest of the world?

Norman Kohlberger (NK): It's a lot different, and yet has a lot of similarities, depending on how you look at it. If you look at Internet connectivity, India is very similar to Australia. Australia has roughly 3 per cent of its population on broadband, and the rest on dial-up. But, Australia has three main telecom companies versus India, which has lots of regional TelCos. But the threats here, with the Internet experience, are no different from anywhere else. I'd probably say that in some instances, it's somewhat higher.

D: Would it be correct to say that the threat visibility has gone up in the past month, as compared to the statistics over the past six months? Is that a matter of concern?

NK: Yes, we are concerned. We have seen more activity—in a certain sense. The method of distribution of the malicious code that was sent out, exploited a vulnerability in Windows. Earlier, when you sent a virus it was attached to e-mail. Not everyone had e-mail, or not everyone was downloading files, but now everyone's got Windows, and is connected to the Internet.

It's also a change in the mentality. Earlier it was the corporations that were targeted, but with Blaster and SoBig, they have targeted individuals. When a corporation gets hurt, most people go "Ok, yes, we understand that's not very good." But they get angry when it happens to them personally at home. It leaves a bitter taste in the mouth, and it's changing the way people are looking at their Internet experience.

D: But this is not the first time a virus is exploiting a vulnerability in Windows...

NK: True, but not as many different variants in a short period of time, and that's what made the difference. Mobile connectivity has opened up a whole new threat, because now, you don't have to be plugged into a wire. There is a whole new entry point which we are looking at, and trying to produce solutions for. And not just for corporations. In the US and on a global basis, about 86 per cent of people are storing sensitive information on their PCs... addresses, credit card numbers, phone numbers, birth dates, etc.

D: Do you believe that the problem lies with the OS, or are people just getting smarter and launching more sophisticated attacks?

NK: I think they are getting smarter. As more and more people get on the Internet, your user base becomes bigger. They start younger and younger, and the Internet has been around for 10 to 15 years; more and more people understand how to manipulate it, and I think



Once is too often

that's what is happening. It's just the base that's getting broader, and it's a competitive world.

D: What sort of a threat do you see for the wireless platform?

NK: Right now, we are positioned where the PC was 10 years ago. The market penetration of PDAs is right now, I believe, 22 million world-wide. It seems to be exploding faster than the PC penetration rate and by the year 2006, there will be approximately 90 million devices out there. So as soon as you get that many devices out there, then they become vulnerable.

D: Is there going to be a NAV2008 for microwave ovens?

NK: Well, we might get down to that point...

D: ...Something like "Help, my toaster's burnt my toast!"?

NK: [Laughs] ...possible...it would be a sad world if everyone's toast got burnt, and if they didn't have an anti-virus program!

D: Symantec has, in the past, spoken of how over 70 per cent of children receive inappropriate e-mail. How does Symantec intend to deal with it?

NK: Spam is not just a nuisance, but a threat. It is a resource threat, it eats up bandwidth, eats into server space. Right now 37 per cent of all e-mail world-wide is spam. By the end of 2003, Gartner predicts that 50 per cent will be spam. If you were to send some of the stuff you see in spam by post, you would be in jail! It's criminal, because from the littlest kid to the world's biggest government, everyone is getting the same thing.

We have had a filtering capability in the Internet Security suite since last year, and have now brought out a product to deal specifically with spam.

D: What's going to be Symantec's biggest threat tomorrow?

NK: I think the future is going to be about increased wireless connectivity, open operating systems in such devices that can, and will, get customised. That's where we see threats rising. The next big one within the coming two years will be PDAs, and then after that it's going to be phones.

D: So increased wireless connectivity and wireless devices will be the next wild frontier?

NK: Yes, that's correct. As more and more people purchase such products and use them, there's going to be faster connectivity and the threat increases. ■